

IELTS Writing: No Ideas Pack

Book 7 · Beat blank-mind panic and generate usable ideas fast

Stratum IELTS · stratumielts.com

Edition 2026 · Original content

Part of the Stratum IELTS Writing Guide Series

Who this book is for

Your biggest pain is not grammar.

It is this moment:

You read the question... and your mind is empty.
The clock is moving. You panic. You write anything.

This book trains a **3-minute idea system** so you never start from zero.

Series map

#	Book	Pain it solves
1	Structure Pack	"I don't know the essay shape"
6	Stuck at 6.5	"My score won't move"
7	No Ideas Pack (this book)	"I freeze and have nothing to say"

Contents

1. Why your mind goes blank
 2. The 3-minute idea system
 3. Idea lenses (steal these)
 4. Prompt → ideas worked examples
 5. Emergency phrases when you are stuck
 6. 10 practice prompts with starter ideas
 7. Next step on Stratum IELTS
-

1. Why your mind goes blank

Blank mind usually means one of these:

1. You try to find a "perfect clever opinion"
2. You search memory for advanced vocabulary first
3. You panic about band score before content
4. The topic feels unfamiliar (law, environment, culture)

Fix mindset: IELTS does not need genius ideas.
It needs **clear, relevant, supportable** ideas.

A simple idea with a clear example beats a brilliant idea you cannot explain.

2. The 3-minute idea system

Use this every Task 2. Practise until automatic.

Minute 1 — Decode

Underline:

- topic
- task words (*agree? both views? problems/solutions?*)
- any double question

Write one sentence:

I must answer: _____

Minute 2 — Generate with lenses

Ask 4 fast questions (next section).

Write bullet fragments, not full sentences.

Minute 3 — Select

Keep only **2** bullets for body paragraphs.

Cross out the rest.

Add one example keyword for each.

Position: _____

Body 1: _____ Exam: _____

Body 2: _____ Exam: _____

Then write. Do not invent a third big idea in paragraph 3 unless the question forces it.

3. Idea lenses (use 2–3 per essay)

When stuck, force ideas through these lenses:

1) People

Who is affected? students / workers / parents / elderly / governments

2) Money

cost, fees, taxes, income, inequality, investment

3) Time

short-term vs long-term effects

4) Access / fairness

who can use this opportunity, who is left out

5) Skills / education

what people learn or fail to learn

6) Health / stress

physical or mental impact

7) Environment / city life

pollution, space, transport, housing

8) Technology

speed, privacy, jobs, dependency

You do not need all eight. Pick the two that fit the question fastest.

4. Worked examples (prompt → ideas)

Example 1

Question: Some people think unpaid community service should be compulsory in high schools. Agree or disagree?

Lens pick: skills + society/fairness

Ideas

- Body 1: builds social awareness (meet needs outside own life)
Example: tutoring younger students
- Body 2: develops workplace skills (teamwork, time management)
Example: library or care-home shifts
- Position: largely agree, if hours stay limited

Example 2

Question: Do the advantages of online shopping outweigh the disadvantages?

Lens pick: time/money + local business/city

Ideas

- Advantage: convenience + lower prices for busy workers
- Disadvantage: pressure on local shops / fewer local jobs
- Judgement: advantages outweigh *if* consumer protection and local support exist
(or: disadvantages outweigh in small towns — choose one clear side)

Example 3

Question: Many cities have expensive housing. What problems does this cause, and what solutions can you suggest?

Lens pick: people + money

Problems

- long commutes / stress
- young people delay independence

Solutions

- increase affordable housing supply
- improve transport to cheaper areas

No fancy theory required — clear and exam-ready.

5. Emergency phrases when you are stuck

Use these only to unlock thinking, then personalise.

If you need a position fast

- *I largely agree because... and...*
- *I disagree overall, although...*
- *The advantages outweigh the disadvantages because...*

If you need an example fast

- *For instance, in many large cities...*
- *A clear example is university students who...*
- *This can be seen when workers...*

If the topic feels unknown

Translate it into daily life:

- government policy → "who pays / who benefits"
- culture topic → "young vs older people"
- science topic → "cost, safety, access"

Never do this in panic

- copy a memorised essay on a different topic
- write three shallow ideas with no development
- spend 15 minutes planning vocabulary lists

6. 10 practice prompts + starter ideas

For each: take 3 minutes, write position + 2 ideas, then (optional) full essay.

1. **Free university**

Ideas: equal access vs tax burden / quality risk

2. **Children & foreign languages early**

Ideas: brain flexibility vs curriculum overload

3. **Remote work**

Ideas: work-life balance vs weaker teamwork / isolation

4. **Higher fuel prices vs public transport**

Ideas: demand reduction vs fairness + better alternatives

5. **Advertising to children**

Ideas: consumer pressure vs parental responsibility / regulation

6. **Gap year before university**

Ideas: maturity/experience vs delayed study / cost

7. **More parks in cities**

Ideas: health/quality of life vs land cost for housing

8. **Exams vs continuous assessment**

Ideas: standard measure vs stress / broader skills

9. **Tourism growth**

Ideas: jobs/income vs overcrowding / local disruption

10. **AI in education**

Ideas: personalised practice vs cheating / weaker independent thinking

Drill rule: for one week, do only the 3-minute plan (no full essay) on 2 prompts/day.
Speed of idea selection is the skill.

7. Next step on Stratum IELTS

1. Pick prompt #3 or #10.
2. Run the 3-minute system on paper.
3. Write the essay in 35 minutes + 5 edit.
4. Check it at <https://stratumielts.com>.
5. Ask only one feedback question: *Were my two ideas distinct and relevant?*

If your score is stuck even when ideas exist, use **Book 6: Stuck at 6.5 Pack**.

Pocket card (memorise)

1. Decode the task
2. Run 2 lenses
3. Keep only 2 ideas + examples
4. Write
5. Edit

Blank mind is normal.
No system is optional.

About this booklet

Published by **Stratum IELTS** · stratumielts.com
Original content · Edition 2026 · For personal study
Independent IELTS study resource.

End of Book 7 — No Ideas Pack · stratumielts.com